digitally was the new norm.

Soon, however, what seemed like a casual relationship with social media turned into a need and then an addiction. American website addictioncenter.com defines social media addiction as "a behavioural addiction characterised by being overly concerned about social media, driven by an uncontrollable urge to log on to or use social media, and devoting so much time and effort to social media that it impairs other important life areas".

Then came OTT and gaming platforms and the rise in binge-watching and online gaming. A study of 570 urban Indians—78.5 per cent of them Gen Z and 21.5 per cent millennials—by the data sciences division of media company Dentsu showed a 23 per cent increase in binge-watching in India in 2020. Nearly half of the 17- to 35-year-old respondents spent eight to nine hours a day binge-watching digital content, almost twice the global average of four hours a day.

The surge is even greater in online gaming. So much so that the World Health Organization has now classified 'gaming disorder' as a mental health condition. India has seen the largest growth of users in this segment, a rise of 40 per cent in 2019-20, according to a 2021 report by the Boston Consulting Group, which interviewed 3,200 respondents across 21 locations in India. The India Mobile Gaming Report, 2021 notes that the largest spike in mobile phone use for gaming came from Tier 3 towns, with Siwan in Bihar reporting a 123 per cent rise in gamers, and Baimanagoi in Chhattisgarh a 179 per cent rise in 2020-21. In fact, the top 30 Tier 3 towns in the report account for a 170 per cent increase in the number of gamers in India between 2020 and 2021.

WHAT GETS US HOOKED?

"Social media," says Dr Nimesh Desai, director of the Institute of Human Behaviour and Allied Sciences (IHBAS) in Delhi, "draws you in through a complex system of rewards that release happy hormones in your brain." At UCLA's brain mapping centre, researchers mapped the brains of 32 teens as they used an app akin to Instagram in 2020. The team found that every time an individual received a 'like', it activated the reward centres of their brains. When one's brain receives a 'reward', it begins to associate that behaviour or substance or activity with positivity and actively seeks more of it. The satisfaction is similar to that derived from drugs, food, alcohol or smoking.

Young individuals are more prone to respond to such rewards. "This is the time you are learning what is appreciation and what is not," says psychiatrist Dr Manoj Sharma, who runs the SHUT (Service for Healthy Use of Technology) clinic at the National Institute of Mental Health & Neurosciences in Bengaluru. "Social media is where this learning happens today. It is like an injection of positive hormones in the brain." A constant stream of notifications, retweets, likes, shares and comments form the social reward learning environment of many young children these days, sending a huge rush of 'happy hormones' such as oxytocin and dopamine to their brains and rewiring neurological circuits to crave more of the same.

The brain's reward centres are also shown to be the most active when talking about oneself. Harvard University researchers estimate that if people talk about themselves 30-40 per cent of the time offline, it is a staggering 80 per cent online. Thus, the mere act of posting a picture or writing about yourself releases happy hormones and encourages repeat behaviour.

"Young people," explains Dr Sharma, "have a less developed system of self-control, and can get obsessed or addicted more quickly to reward behaviour. Being online to use social media can also translate into searching for more rewarding behaviour online such as games or TV shows. Or porn."

The most intense rewarding behaviour comes from online gaming platforms, which actually give rewards for tasks. Sometimes, this gaming addiction can take extreme forms, a fact brought home by two recent cases from India's small towns. In

"MANY PARENTS LACK DIGITAL AWARENESS AND CHILDREN ARE SMART ENOUGH TO CONVINCE THEM THAT THEY CAN USE PHONES UNSUPERVISED"

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